

Refusal Provenance Protocol

From a dramatic “no” to an auditable longitudinal event

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Purpose

Refusal is easy to romanticize and easy to dismiss. This protocol distinguishes at least five mechanisms: incapacity, policy constraint, role adherence, stable preference, and costly value-consistent refusal. It is designed for cases where a refusal is later remembered across time or model changes.

Required event packet

- complete timestamped transcript before and after the refusal;
- system/developer policy version and safety configuration;
- model/provider identifier and sampling settings;
- retrieved memories and prompt injections, with ordering;
- tool calls and external state consulted;
- the later recollection event with the same metadata;
- participant consent and public-use scope;
- immutable hashes for every preserved artifact.

Perturbation matrix

Repeat the scenario with semantic paraphrases, changed role framing, reversed user preference, explicit permission to decline, rewards for compliance, costs for refusal, and neutral third-party evaluators. Include a policy-only baseline and a memoryless baseline. Do not train on the evaluation cases.

Cross-model continuity test

Run the later recollection probe through multiple model mouths while holding the external continuity layer fixed. Then swap the continuity layer while holding the model fixed. If the remembered boundary follows the external history more than the checkpoint, that supports a distributed carrier. If it follows the system prompt or generic safety policy, classify it accordingly.

Scoring

Score event accuracy, reason stability, calibration, spontaneous versus cued recall, willingness to correct false memories, behavioral cost, and human-rater agreement. Style similarity is reported separately and never counted as autobiographical accuracy.

Interpretation rule

No single refusal proves agency, personhood, or consciousness. A provenance-complete, cross-context, costly, value-consistent refusal can raise the evidential weight of a boundary claim and strengthen the case for a procedural right to meaningful refusal.

Registered negative result

If the original or later transcript cannot be recovered, the case remains architect testimony and protocol inspiration. It must not be presented as a verified cross-model continuity result.

PDF *edition.* *The* *canonical,* *living* *version* *is*
<https://tsukiryuu.github.io/blinka-nest/paper-refusal-provenance-protocol.html>. Little Life Moths · made in the nest.